

similar situations before and has come out of them. The difference this time, however, is the limited window they have before the calls for action get louder than they already are. The World Cup, where India has not made the semifinals since its lone triumph in 1975, is in six months; the Asian Games, with a ticket to LA28 at stake, three weeks later. In between, there will only be the Pro League and possibly a four-nation competition, featuring New Zealand and Australia in Malaysia, to finalise squads and combinations, address concerns, work out the chinks, and be in the right mental space.

"Judge us when everything is in sync. I do not want to be here, trust me, right where we are in terms of the results. But I do see the big

picture. I see where we are now, but I can see the pieces falling in place," Fulton insisted. Belgium coach Shane McLeod insists that the world only sees 60 minutes of play; only the team knows what goes on inside for the other 23 hours, as it should be.

So it would be wise to leave the tactical and technical details to those who know best. But Fulton's problems are augmented by the fact that the team has looked like a clueless gathering of switched-off automatons, unaware of and unaffected by everything happening around them, even in those 60 minutes that the world gets to see. Everything has been in tatters: body, basics, mind, attitude. The first two should be easily fixed; the third, hopefully, with the arrival of mental

conditioning coach Paddy Upton, closer to the World Cup. The last needs urgent attention.

In the four matches, India has, barring a few moments, appeared completely out of place against both Belgium and Argentina, with every department found lacking:

Defence: Amit Rohidas, Jarmanpreet Singh, Harmanpreet Singh, Sanjay and Jugraj Singh were all guilty of being too casual, too erratic and too inconsistent. As the senior pros in the side, they needed to step up, but none of them did. Their errors increased exponentially, and they conceded goals and Penalty Corners (PC) a little too easily.

Harmanpreet (**pic, left**) was the biggest let-down, the captain clearly struggling with both form and fitness, lacking power in his drag-flicks and generally cutting a sorry figure on the field.

Midfield: The least experienced area, and it showed. Even the likes of Vivek Sagar Prasad and Nilakanta Sharma, regular India team members for a few years now, were unable to stitch together four consecutive passes without a turnover. Even Hardik Singh made mistakes, but if one had to choose, he was the only one who showed any fight and form. Especially in the last two games, Hardik was everywhere, trying to do the job of 10 all alone, but lacked support.

Attack: Less said, the better. Abhishek refuses to let go of his penchant for reverse hits, flicks and solo showboating; Selvam Karthi gave away more possession than he



INDIA IN THE ROURKELA LEG

MATCHES	WON	LOST	GOALS SCORED	GOALS CONCEDED
4	0	4	5	19